

From a working build to a company

The whole path: getting EverEcho safely online, finding the first ten paying families, choosing the channel that scales, and the arithmetic a billion-dollar outcome would actually require.

Written the way the product was built. Every claim carries its evidence class.

Nothing here is a projection dressed as a fact, no market figure is invented, and the parts of this plan most likely to fail are named rather than buried.

For

The founder

Covers

Day 0 to Year 7

Companion to

Pitch and Manual
(57pp)

Date

1 September 2026

How to use this

A chief of staff does three things: keeps the sequence honest, makes sure decisions actually get made, and says the thing nobody else will say. This document does all three, in that order.

The evidence discipline carries over

The build refused to state anything it could not support. A plan written to a looser standard than the product would be worse than useless, so every consequential claim here is labelled:

VERIFIED	Established by running the code or reading the repository. You can check it yourself today.
INFERENCE	My reasoning from things that are verified. Should hold, but it is an argument, not an observation.
ASSUMPTION	A number or belief I have adopted so the plan can proceed. You must replace these with real ones.
UNKNOWN	I do not know, and neither does anyone until it is measured. These are the research tasks.

There are no market-size figures in this document, no competitor funding amounts, and no citations to reports I have not read. Where you need those, they are named as research tasks with the question stated precisely. A plan built on invented numbers fails in exactly the way this product refuses to.

What I have assumed about you

These shape the recommendations. Where one is wrong, the section that depends on it says so, and says what changes.

You are the founder and the technical owner	ASSUMPTION
India-based, with reach into the diaspora	ASSUMPTION
Small or no team today	ASSUMPTION
Not yet funded; runway is personal	ASSUMPTION
No paying customer yet	VERIFIED — the pricing page describes a pilot with no price set
Wants a large outcome, not a lifestyle business	from your request

IF ANY OF THOSE ARE WRONG

Tell me which, and the sections that change are §5 (the first decisions), §14 (bootstrap versus raise) and §16 (the staged path). Everything else holds.

How the parts fit

Part I	Where you actually are	— read once, carefully
Part II	Getting online safely	— the next 8 weeks, do in order
Part III	Building the business	— months 2–12
Part IV	Money	— decide before month 6
Part V	Governance and risk	— set up before the first real family
Part VI	Your operating system	— from Monday, every week

Sections are numbered continuously and the contents page links to each. Part II is the part to act on this week; Parts III–VI are the parts to read now and return to.

Contents

PART I — WHERE YOU ACTUALLY ARE

1	The honest position	6
2	What a unicorn actually requires	8
3	The five structural problems	11
4	The three assets you actually have	14

PART II — GETTING ONLINE SAFELY

5	Horizon 0: the decisions only you can make	18
6	Horizon 1: from “runs on a laptop” to “safe to launch”	22
7	The launch gate	26
8	Horizon 2: the first ten families	28

PART III — BUILDING THE BUSINESS

9	Pricing and the business model	31
10	The channel question	33
11	Growth without breaking your own rules	36
12	The metrics that matter	38
13	The team, in hiring order	40

PART IV — MONEY

14	Bootstrap or raise	43
15	If you raise	44
16	The staged path to scale	46

PART V — GOVERNANCE AND RISK

17	Binding the refusal so it survives you	49
18	The risk register	51
19	When I would tell you to stop	53

PART VI — YOUR OPERATING SYSTEM

20	The cadence	55
21	The first thirty days	56
22	Open decisions, waiting on you	58

Each entry links to its section. No market-size figure, competitor funding amount, growth statistic or customer reference appears anywhere in this document, because I have not verified any and inventing them would make the plan worse than having none.

PART I

Where you actually are

Four pieces of ground truth. Read this part once, carefully, before you act on anything in the rest of the document.

1 The honest position

You have built something most funded startups do not have: a complete, tested, running product with the hard parts genuinely finished. You have not yet built a company, and the gap between those two things is larger than it feels from inside the code.

What is real VERIFIED

All of this can be checked by anyone with the repository, today:

A running application, end to end	3 apps, 7 packages, ~25,000 lines
Database schema with enforced isolation	50 tables, 28 under forced RLS
Versioned API, generated from its own validators	70 operations
Screens	33 routes
Tests that actually ran	193 unit and integration, no mocks
Browser and accessibility	54 tests, 0 WCAG 2.2 AA violations
AI evaluation	32/32, all four blocking targets met
Documentation	15 documents, plus a 57-page product PDF

That is a genuinely strong engineering position, and it is worth being precise about why: the parts you finished are the parts that are normally faked. Consent, provenance, isolation and deletion are usually a policy page and a hope. Here they are a pure authorisation function, forced row-level security, a verification step that drops unsupported sentences, and a resumable deletion that issues a receipt. That work is real and it is not easily copied.

What is not real, and must not be described as if it were

CLAIM SOMEONE MIGHT MAKE	THE ACTUAL POSITION
"It's live"	It runs locally. It has never been deployed. There is no production authentication path at all — <code>AUTH_DRIVER=local</code> is refused when <code>NODE_ENV=production</code> , by design. VERIFIED
"We can take payment"	Checkout and refund are written; <code>verifyWebhook</code> returns <code>null</code> . It fails closed, which is the safe direction, and it means billing is not wired. VERIFIED
"We have users"	Five demonstration accounts and one invented person. Every name, date and recording in the seed is fabricated for demonstration and says so. VERIFIED
"It's compliant"	Every legal string in the product is a draft written by engineers. No lawyer has read the consent copy, the teach-back wording, the terms or the succession screen. VERIFIED
"It scales"	Eight integrations — Docker, S3, Redis, pgvector, hosted composition, hosted speech-to-text, hosted OCR, SMTP — are complete, type-checked and have never been executed . VERIFIED
"It transcribes recordings"	The local speech adapter cannot recognise speech . Real audio requires a paid provider that has never been connected. This is a cost line, not just a task. VERIFIED

FIX THIS SENTENCE BEFORE THE SITE IS PUBLIC

Your pricing page currently reads: “*We are working with a small number of families and being honest about what that means.*” Present tense. You are not working with any families. It is a small thing and it is exactly the kind of small thing that, in a product whose entire proposition is that it does not overstate, will be the first thing a sharp journalist or investor quotes back at you. Change it to the future or conditional tense today.

VERIFIED — `apps/web/src/app/pricing/page.tsx`

The one-line summary of your position

You have a finished engine, an unfinished car, and no road. The engine is the hard part and you already did it. Parts II and III of this document are about the car and the road, in that order, and the sequencing matters more than the speed.

2 What a unicorn actually requires

You asked for a path to a billion-dollar company. The useful response is not encouragement; it is arithmetic. The arithmetic has one clear conclusion, and it should change what you build next.

SAID ONCE, PLAINLY

Nobody can promise you a unicorn, and any adviser who does is selling something. Outcomes at that scale are rare enough that no plan produces one on demand. What a plan *can* do is make the outcome possible instead of arithmetically impossible — and most companies foreclose it early, by choosing a price. That is the whole content of this section.

Working backwards from the number

A \$1 billion valuation is a multiple applied to revenue. Software businesses have traded across a wide band depending on growth, margin and the market's mood, and I am not going to invent a current figure. Take **10× forward revenue** as a working assumption and treat the answer as an order of magnitude, not a target. **ASSUMPTION**

Target valuation	\$1,000,000,000
Working revenue multiple	÷ 10
Annual recurring revenue required	\$100,000,000

So: **roughly \$100M of annual recurring revenue**. Everything now turns on one variable — what one archive pays you per year.

Four ways to get to \$100M, and what each demands

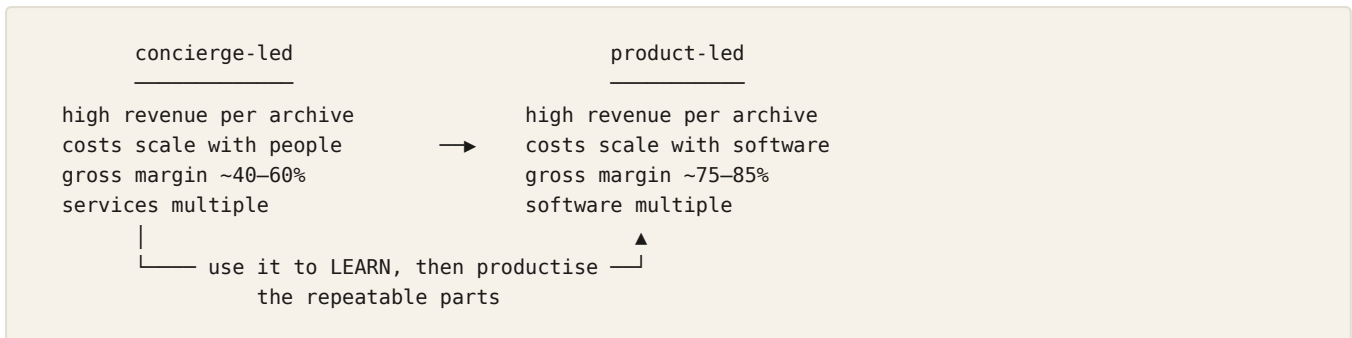
	MODEL	REVENUE PER ARCHIVE/YR	PAYING ARCHIVES NEEDED	WHAT HAS TO BE TRUE
A	Mass-market consumer subscription	\$120	833,000	A consumer product with viral or near-zero-cost acquisition. You do not have one, and \$3 explains why this category structurally resists it.
B	Premium consumer subscription	\$600	167,000	Still a very large number of families paying meaningfully every year, sustained for years. Possible; hard.
C	Concierge: guided capture plus preservation	\$2,000	50,000	Reachable through channels rather than advertising. The most plausible consumer-facing route. Margin risk — see below.
D	Institutional accounts	\$20,000	5,000	Sold to organisations that already hold the relationship and the occasion. 5,000 accounts is a normal B2B outcome, not a fantasy.

THE CONCLUSION, WHICH IS THE WHOLE POINT OF THE SECTION

A low-priced consumer subscription cannot reach this outcome for this product. 833,000 families paying every year, in a category where people demonstrably postpone the thing for decades, is not a plan — it is a wish. Price high, sell through institutions, or both. Everything in Part III follows from this line. **INFERENCE**

The margin trap inside model C

Model C reaches high revenue per archive by putting a person in the loop: someone conducts the interview well, someone helps an eighty-year-old through the review queue. That works, and it is probably how you should start. But a business whose costs scale with headcount earns a services multiple, not a software multiple — and at a services multiple, \$100M of revenue is not a billion-dollar company.



The resolution is sequencing, not choosing. Run concierge deliberately and temporarily: it is the fastest way to learn what a good interview actually is, and every hour a human spends is a specification for something to automate. Then move each repeatable piece into the product and watch gross margin climb. If gross margin is not rising by the fiftieth archive, the concierge model has become the company. **INFERENCE**

The unit economics worksheet

You cannot price until you know what one archive costs to serve, and you do not know yet, because the providers that cost money have never been connected. Fill this in during Horizon 1 — it is a two-day task and it determines every number in Part III.

COST LINE	DRIVER	STATUS
ONE-TIME, PER ARCHIVE		
Speech-to-text on real recordings	hours × per-hour rate	UNKNOWN no provider connected
Document OCR	pages	UNKNOWN
Interview facilitation, if concierge	hours × loaded cost	UNKNOWN
Onboarding and review hand-holding	hours	UNKNOWN — expect this to be the surprise
EVERY YEAR, PER ARCHIVE, FOREVER		
Object storage for originals	GB × rate × 12	UNKNOWN
Backups and a second region	storage × copies	UNKNOWN
Retrieval, embedding and composition	queries	small; local adapters are cheap
Support, including emotionally heavy support	tickets × minutes	UNKNOWN

THE LINE THAT CAN QUIETLY BANKRUPT THIS COMPANY

Storage is perpetual; subscriptions are not. You are promising to preserve something. If a family pays for three years and stops, and you keep the archive because deleting a dead parent's recordings feels monstrous, you have taken on an unfunded liability that grows with every customer you win. Video makes it far worse than audio — the same hour of material can be one to two orders of magnitude larger.

Two structural answers, and you should take both: **(1) default to audio**, price video as a deliberate upgrade; **(2) fund preservation explicitly** — either the subscription must continue for the archive to be hosted (and export is always free, so nothing is held hostage), or a one-time *preservation payment* is priced to cover storage for a stated term. Whichever you choose, say it in plain words on the pricing page before anyone pays. **INFERENCE**

A perpetual-care endowment is the model cemeteries use, and it may carry trust, escrow or reserve obligations depending on jurisdiction. Put it on the list for counsel in \$5 rather than designing it yourself. **UNKNOWN — legal question**

What I would actually aim at

Not \$100M. Aim at the milestone that makes the next one possible, and let the arithmetic above tell you only one thing: **do not choose a cheap price**. A cheap price is the single decision that forecloses the outcome you asked me about, and it is usually made casually, in an afternoon, by a founder who feels awkward asking for money.

3 The five structural problems

Not risks — risks are in §18. These are properties of the category that will not go away no matter how well you execute. Each one has an answer. None of the answers is “work harder”.

Problem 1 — The refusal does not demo

A voice clone sells itself in fifteen seconds. Your most important behaviour is *declining to answer*, which is invisible in a screenshot and reads as a limitation to anyone who has not thought about it for ten minutes. You are selling the absence of a failure, and absences do not demo. **INFERENCE**

WHAT TO DO ABOUT IT

- **Demo the pair, never the answer alone.** Ask a question the archive can answer, then ask one it cannot, in the same breath. The second screen is the product. Your existing Figures 8 and 9 already do this — make it the fixed shape of every demo you ever give.
- **Demo to the storyteller, not the buyer.** The parent is the one for whom the refusal is worth money. Watch an older person realise that the system will not put words in their mouth; that reaction is your marketing asset, and you cannot script it.
- **Show the click-through.** Answer → cited sentence → transcript → the actual recording, in one continuous motion. That chain is a foreign-key walk, not a citation string, and it is the thing competitors cannot fake.

Problem 2 — The buyer is not the user

An adult child finds you, is moved, and pays. Then the entire value of the purchase depends on a seventy-eight-year-old who has never seen your website agreeing to spend hours recording, and then reviewing what was recorded. Your product correctly refuses to proceed without them — which is right, and which means **your conversion rate is decided by a person you cannot market to.** **INFERENCE**

WHAT TO DO ABOUT IT

- **Build the asking artifact.** The hardest moment in this product is a child asking a parent. Give them the words: a letter, a card, a page written to be forwarded, that explains what this is and — crucially — what it refuses to do. This is a product feature, not a marketing asset, and it does not exist yet.
- **Make the first session absurdly easy.** No account for the parent on day one if you can avoid it. A phone call, a scheduled session, someone else driving.
- **Measure the funnel that matters:** payment → storyteller consents → first recording → **first approved memory**. That last step is your real activation event. Everything before it is a promise.

Problem 3 — There is no occasion

Everyone intends to do this and almost nobody does, which is the observation the product is founded on. The uncomfortable corollary: **the same force that creates the market suppresses the purchase.** Intent without a trigger produces a bookmarked website and no revenue. **INFERENCE**

WHAT TO DO ABOUT IT

Stop trying to manufacture urgency — you cannot, and attempting it lands you squarely in the guilt mechanics the product refuses. Instead, **attach to occasions other people already own:**

- A milestone birthday — seventieth, eightieth
- Retirement
- A diagnosis, or a hospice admission
- Moving out of a long-held home
- A first grandchild
- A significant anniversary
- Estate or will preparation
- Citizenship, or a return visit to a country left behind

Every one of those moments is already attended by somebody — a wealth adviser, a hospice social worker, a senior-living director, a family lawyer. **That is the argument for §10, and it is the single most important strategic idea in this document after the pricing conclusion in §2.**

Problem 4 — You have deliberately removed your retention levers

The standard subscription playbook retains customers by bringing them back: digests, reminders, streaks, nudges. Your product has **no notification scheduler at all**, on purpose, because reminders about a parent's mortality become guilt with almost no effort. **VERIFIED**

That is the correct decision and I would not reverse it. But be clear about what it costs: an archive that is finished is an archive nobody opens, and a subscription nobody opens is a subscription somebody eventually cancels.

WHAT TO DO ABOUT IT

- **Sell custody, not engagement.** Nobody expects to visit their safe-deposit box monthly. Price and describe this as preservation. Then *do not measure daily actives* — you will panic at a number that means nothing here.
- **Let the family be the retention.** Each additional family member with access is another person for whom cancelling is unthinkable. Members-per-archive is a retention metric; sessions-per-week is not.
- **Growth, not nudges.** An archive can gain new chapters years later. Offer that when the family initiates, and only then — a returning customer is welcome, a chased one is a violation of the thing you built.
- **Handle the true test honestly:** the renewal that arrives after the storyteller has died. Decide the policy now, in §17, while it is abstract. You will not think clearly about it the first time it happens to a real family.

Problem 5 — The verdict arrives years late

A family cannot tell whether the archive is any good until they need it — which may be a decade away, and often after the person has died. This breaks two loops at once: **word of mouth is slow**, because nobody has the experience that makes them evangelise; and **your quality feedback is slow**, because the failure mode — a thin archive, the wrong questions asked, the important story never told — only becomes visible when it is far too late to fix. **INFERENCE**

WHAT TO DO ABOUT IT

- **Manufacture an early verdict.** Deliver something the family holds within weeks: the printed biography draft, a short edited audio piece, a set of stories read at a birthday. An artefact that lands while everyone is alive is what converts a customer into an advocate a decade early.
- **Grade the archive, not the software.** Build a coverage view — which decades, which relationships, which themes are thin. That turns an unmeasurable outcome into a visible gap the family can close now.
- **Interview quality is the actual product.** Two archives with identical software differ enormously based on what was asked. Treat the question set as your core IP, version it, and improve it deliberately. This is also what the concierge phase in §2 is for.

READ THESE FIVE TOGETHER

They all point the same direction: **do not run this as a self-serve consumer subscription**. Sell high-value archives through people who own the occasion, deliver something tangible early, and let custody — not engagement — carry retention. Parts II and III are that plan.

4 The three assets you actually have

Section 3 was the honest accounting of what is hard. This is the honest accounting of what is rare — and all three of these are more valuable than the traction you do not yet have.

Asset 1 — The refusal is a position, and the market is moving toward it

You are not a slightly-safer version of the simulation products. You are the opposite category, and you can say so in one sentence that a stranger understands: *we record what a living person actually said, we show you where every sentence came from, and we will never pretend to be them.*

This is worth more than it looks, for three reasons:

- **Every bad story about a griefbot is your advertisement.** You do not need to attack anyone. You need to be the obvious thing a journalist calls for the contrasting quote, and the obvious thing a reader searches for afterwards.
- **It is the only version institutions can touch.** A hospice, a university archive, a bank's private-client arm, a religious community — none of them can put their name on a product that simulates the dead. The refusal is not a constraint on your enterprise sales; it is the precondition for having any. **INFERENCE**
- **It is enforced, not promised.** Anyone can claim restraint. You can point at a policy compiler that refuses the document, a function that discards a first-person answer, and a test that fails if someone removes either. That is a difference you can demonstrate in a meeting.

THE COST OF THIS POSITION

You will spend the rest of the company's life being mistaken for the thing you refuse to be. Budget for it: a permanent, prominent, plainly-worded explanation, repeated more often than feels necessary, forever. The *Trust and consent* page already does this well — treat it as a primary surface, not a footer link.

Asset 2 — The machinery underneath might be the larger company

Strip away the family archive and look at what you built: a consent document that compiles to an enforceable policy; a pure authorisation function whose obligations become part of the SQL query rather than a filter applied afterwards; retrieval that cannot see what the viewer may not know exists; a verification step that drops any sentence its citation does not support; forced tenant isolation at the database; and deletion that is resumable and produces a receipt.

That is a general answer to a question a great many organisations are being asked right now: *how do you let an AI system read sensitive material without it leaking, inventing, or exceeding what the subject agreed to?* Adjacent buyers exist in oral history and archives, hospice and palliative care, estate and private-client services, journalism and documentary research, and any regulated setting where an answer must cite and abstain.

UNKNOWN — none of this is validated; it is a hypothesis with a strong prior

DECISION — DO NOT MAKE THIS ONE YET

The temptation, in about month four, will be to pivot from families to infrastructure because enterprise revenue looks closer. Resist it until you have run §8. Two reasons: the consumer product is where you learn what the consent model must actually do, and an infrastructure company with no application is a crowded, undifferentiated place to arrive.

Recommendation: treat this as an option you hold, not a plan you execute. Keep the packages cleanly separated (they already are), take an enterprise conversation if one walks in, and revisit deliberately at the §16 branch point — not in a discouraged week.

Asset 3 — Verifiable honesty, in a market with almost none of it

You have a document that says “*Not ready for a real family's memories*”, a table listing eight integrations that were written and never executed, and a product that answers a question it cannot support with a fixed sentence declining to answer. Nobody does this. It is worth a great deal, in three specific ways.

WITH	WHY IT CONVERTS
Storytellers	They are deciding whether to hand you the most private material they have. Restraint they can verify is the only argument that works on someone genuinely reluctant — and the reluctant ones are the ones with the stories worth keeping.
Institutions	Procurement, ethics committees and compliance teams are trying to find out what you are hiding. Handing over the readiness document unprompted collapses months of that.
Investors	You have no traction. What you have instead is evidence about the founder: a complete, tested, documented product with the hard parts finished and the gaps named. For a pre-traction round, that <i>is</i> the diligence. INFERENCE

A MOVE I WOULD MAKE IN MONTH ONE

Publish the production-readiness document. Publicly, on the site, including the verdict and the list of things that were never run. Almost nobody will do this, which is exactly why it works: it makes every other claim you make credible, and it costs you nothing you were going to get away with anyway. If it later becomes commercially awkward, that is a signal you have started overstating — which is the failure mode this company most needs an alarm for.

And what you do not have

For completeness, because the assets above are easy to over-read:

A customer	none
A price	not set
A deployed system	none — no production auth exists
Legal clearance on any consent wording	none
A distribution channel	none
Cleared rights to the name	codename, pending trademark clearance
Evidence anyone will pay	none

Every one of those is addressed in Part II or III, in the order that a rational person would address them. The order is not the order they feel urgent in.

PART II

Getting online safely

The next eight weeks, in the order they must actually happen. This is the part to act on this week.

5 Horizon 0: the decisions only you can make

HORIZON 0 Nothing here is engineering. All of it blocks engineering.

Weeks 0-2

Seven decisions. Two of them have hard deadlines imposed by outside parties and should start on day one because they take weeks of somebody else's time.

DECISION 1 — THE NAME

Your own README says EverEcho is “*a working codename pending trademark clearance*”. **VERIFIED** You cannot build a brand, buy a domain properly, print anything, or sign a channel partner on a name you may have to abandon. Every week you delay makes the eventual rename more expensive.

You did one thing very well here: the product name lives in configuration (`PRODUCT_NAME`), so renaming the software is a settings change, not a refactor. The expensive part is everything outside the repository.

Recommendation: start clearance **on day one**, in every jurisdiction you intend to operate in, in the relevant classes. If it is not clearly clearable within three weeks, **rename now** rather than hope. Budget this as the first professional-services money you spend.

DECISION 2 — WHERE THE COMPANY AND THE DATA LIVE

Configuration currently says `JURISDICTION=IN` and `DATA_REGION=local`. **VERIFIED** Those were sensible development defaults and they are now a strategic choice with legal consequences: which law governs consent, where the database physically sits, whether using a US-hosted AI provider constitutes a cross-border transfer, and which regulator you answer to.

Recommendation: incorporate and host where your first ten families are, not where you imagine your hundred-thousandth will be. Keep the region a configuration value, as it already is, and treat a second region as a Horizon 3 problem. Do not architect for a geography you have no customers in.

DECISION 3 — ENGAGE COUNSEL, WITH A WRITTEN BRIEF

This is the highest-leverage thing you will do in the next month, it is blocking item 1 on your own readiness list, and it runs on somebody else's calendar. Start it in week one. The brief is on the next page — do not send “please review our privacy policy”, send the questions.

Recommendation: find counsel with data-protection experience specifically, not a general commercial lawyer. Ask them directly whether they have advised on special-category data and on what happens to personal data when the subject dies. If they hesitate on the second question, keep looking.

DECISION 4 — NAME THE ACCOUNTABLE PERSON

Blocking item 8: *the incident runbook says “escalate” and there is no one to escalate to.* **VERIFIED** If you are solo, the answer is you — but it must be written down, with a name, in the runbook, on the support page, and in whatever you sign with a customer. An accountability that is implied is an accountability that evaporates at exactly the wrong moment.

Recommendation: name yourself today, in writing, in `INCIDENT_RUNBOOK.md`, and commit it. Replace the name when you hire someone; never let the field be empty.

DECISION 5 — AUDIO-FIRST, OR AUDIO AND VIDEO

From the storage arithmetic in §2: video can be one to two orders of magnitude larger than audio for the same hour, and you are promising preservation. This decision sets your cost base permanently and is very painful to reverse once families have uploaded video.

Recommendation: **audio by default**, video as an explicitly priced upgrade with its own storage term stated. Photographs and documents are cheap; treat them as included and encourage them, since they carry enormous emotional weight per megabyte.

DECISION 6 — PROVISIONAL PRICE

Your pricing page currently sets no price at all. **VERIFIED** You cannot run \$8 without one, and \$2 established the one thing you must not do: choose a cheap one.

Recommendation: pick a provisional number in week two using §9, and hold it for the first ten families. Do not discount to close — a discounted first cohort teaches you nothing about willingness to pay, which is the only thing that cohort exists to teach you.

DECISION 7 — A STANCE, NOT A COMMITMENT, ON MONEY

Bootstrap or raise changes your hiring, your speed and how much of §6 you do yourself. §14 argues it properly. You need a provisional stance now because it determines whether you spend the next eight weeks building or talking.

Recommendation: assume bootstrap through §8. Ten paying families is the cheapest, fastest, most honest fundraising asset you can build, and it is worth more in a pitch than any deck you could write instead.

The brief for counsel

Send these as questions. A lawyer given a document to review returns comments; a lawyer given questions returns answers you can act on. Nothing below is legal advice — it is the list of things I would not launch without an answer to.

CONSENT ITSELF

- 1 **Does our consent flow constitute valid, informed consent** in each jurisdiction we will operate in? We record a versioned, hashed policy document plus a “teach-back” in which the storyteller restates in their own words what they agreed to. *Does the teach-back help, hurt, or do nothing legally?*
- 2 **Special-category data.** The product explicitly recognises health, financial, religious, political, sexual-orientation and biometric categories, because life stories contain them. What lawful basis applies, and what additional safeguards are required? **VERIFIED — these are enum values in the schema**
- 3 **Withdrawal.** Consent can be narrowed or revoked at any time and takes effect on the next authorisation check, including on queued background work. Does our implementation satisfy the withdrawal right, and what must we do about material already derived?

THE PEOPLE WHO NEVER AGREED

- 1 **Third parties inside memories.** A story about a living brother contains that brother's personal data, and he has not consented to anything. *What are our obligations to people who appear in someone else's memories?* This is the legal question I would ask first, because it has no obvious technical answer and it is present in essentially every archive.
- 2 **Minors appearing in memories.** We refuse to create profiles for minors, but a grandmother's story mentions her grandchildren by name. What follows from that?
- 3 **Contributors.** A contributor may propose corrections and context about the storyteller. What have they consented to, and what have they asserted about others?

DEATH, WHICH THIS PRODUCT CANNOT AVOID

- 1 **Whose rights are they after death?** Data-protection rights in a deceased person are treated differently across jurisdictions and we must not guess. Who may then exercise access, correction, export and deletion — and who may *refuse* those on the deceased's behalf?
- 2 **Is our succession directive legally effective?** A storyteller names a steward with narrowly delegated tasks. How does that interact with a will, with probate, and with an executor who disagrees? What happens if the steward and the family conflict?
- 3 **Standing instructions.** If a storyteller says “never show this to my son”, is that enforceable after death, and against whom?

COMMERCIAL AND STRUCTURAL

- 1 **Cross-border processing.** If we enable a hosted speech-to-text or composition provider in another country, what is required? We can contractually forbid provider training and set zero retention — is that sufficient?
- 2 **The preservation model.** If we take a one-time payment in exchange for storing something for a long or indefinite term, does that create trust, escrow or reserve obligations? (See §9.)
- 3 **The refundable deposit.** We take a deposit refundable at any time, for any reason, with no conversation required. Confirm the terms, the accounting treatment, and any consumer-protection requirements.

- 4 **Binding the prohibitions.** We want the refusal of voice cloning, likeness generation, persona chat and posthumous simulation to survive a change of management or an acquisition. What is the strongest available instrument — constitutional documents, a golden share, contractual covenants to customers, or something else? (This is §17 and it matters more than it sounds.)

EXPECT ONE OF THESE ANSWERS TO BE EXPENSIVE

My prediction, offered as a prediction and not a fact: **question 4 — third parties inside memories — will come back harder than you expect**, and may require a product change such as a redaction path, a named-person objection route, or narrower default sharing. Better to learn that in week three than in year two. **INFERENCE**

What Horizon 0 produces

- ☐ A name you own, or a decision to rename made deliberately
- ☐ An incorporated entity and a chosen data region
- ☐ Counsel engaged, brief sent, first answers scheduled
- ☐ A named accountable person, committed to the repository
- ☐ Audio-first decided; video priced separately or deferred
- ☐ A provisional price you will not discount
- ☐ A provisional stance on funding
- ☐ The pricing-page tense corrected, so the site claims nothing untrue

6 Horizon 1: from “runs on a laptop” to “safe to launch”

HORIZON 1 Engineering and operations. Synthetic data only, throughout.

Weeks 2-8

First, the three clocks

The most common way a founder loses a month is by treating every task as though it runs on their own clock. It does not. Sort the work by whose calendar it depends on, and start everything on somebody else's calendar **in week one**, even though it completes last.

OTHER PEOPLE'S CLOCK – start day 1, finishes weeks later

- | trademark clearance \$5, decision 1
- | counsel engagement + the brief \$5, decision 3
- | independent security review — book it now, run it week 6
- | accessibility review with disabled users — recruit now, run it week 7

YOUR CLOCK – start week 2, you control the pace

- └ production authentication
- └ connect the eight integrations that never ran
- └ encryption, scanning, backups
- └ hosting, monitoring, on-call

THE MARKET'S CLOCK – starts only after the launch gate in §7

- ↳ the first ten families \$8

THE SINGLE HARDEST RULE IN THIS DOCUMENT

No real person's memories enter the system until every box in §7 is ticked. Not a friendly beta family, not your own grandmother, not “just to test with something real”. The moment real material is in there, you have obligations you cannot yet meet, and the first archive is exactly the one you will care most about having handled badly.

Synthetic data is not a limitation during Horizon 1; it is the point of Horizon 1.

Week by week

WEEK	WHAT SHIPS	WHY IT IS IN THIS POSITION
1	Start every external clock. Correct the pricing-page tense. Name the accountable person.	These cost you hours and buy you weeks.
2-3	Production authentication. OIDC or passkeys, MFA enrolment, <i>and password reset</i> .	Blocking item 4. Without it the product cannot be deployed at all — <code>AUTH_DRIVER=local</code> is refused in production by design. Password reset is not on the blocking list but a pilot without it generates a support crisis in week two. VERIFIED
3	Real secrets. Replace every development placeholder and move them into a secret manager.	<code>SESSION_SECRET</code> and <code>STORAGE_SIGNING_SECRET</code> currently hold strings that literally read <code>dev-only-...-change-me</code> . VERIFIED Shipping either is a total compromise of sessions or of object URLs.
3-4	Run the eight integrations that have never executed.	Each is written and type-checked and unproven. Detailed below — this week also produces your real unit costs.
4-5	Encryption at rest with a customer-managed key; a real malware scanner.	Blocking items 3 and 5. Today anyone with database or backup access reads everything, and the local scanner catches a test file and a mismatched type — it is not an antivirus. VERIFIED
5	Backups, and a restore you actually perform.	Blocking item 6. Your own document says the recovery targets are <i>stated, not measured</i> . Restore into a clean environment and time it. VERIFIED
5-6	Hosting, deploy pipeline, monitoring, alerting, on-call. Instrument OpenTelemetry.	It is configured and not instrumented, so today you would find out about an outage from a customer. VERIFIED
6	Independent security review runs.	Blocking item 2. The isolation is currently tested by the person who wrote it.
7	Accessibility review with disabled users.	Blocking item 7. Zero automated violations is a floor. Your users skew old; some will have low vision, tremor, or hearing loss. This is a core-audience issue, not a compliance checkbox.
8	Fix what the two reviews found. Run the \$7 gate. Legal answers land.	Reserve the week. Both reviews will find things.

The eight integrations, and what each one teaches you

These are complete and were **never executed**, because nothing was reachable from the build environment. **VERIFIED**
Run them in this order; each has a specific first thing to check, and two of them produce numbers you need for pricing.

INTEGRATION	FIRST THING TO CHECK	WHAT IT PRODUCES
Docker Compose	<code>docker compose up</code> — watch the migrate step	Everything else depends on it
S3 or MinIO	Upload, then a presigned download, then deletion	Your storage cost per GB
Redis	That revocation clears keys across <i>two</i> API instances	Proves consent revocation survives horizontal scaling
pgvector	That its results match the portable path	Retrieval quality parity
Hosted speech-to-text	That segment locators still point at real spans	Your largest variable cost — the local adapter cannot recognise speech at all
Hosted OCR	Same — that locators survive	Document handling becomes real
Hosted composition	That verification still drops unsupported claims	Whether you need it at all — see below
SMTP	That no memory content appears in a subject line	The privacy rule most easily broken by a convenience change
Stripe	<code>verifyWebhook</code> returns <code>null</code> — wire signature verification	The ability to be paid

A QUESTION WORTH ASKING BEFORE YOU SPEND ON HOSTED COMPOSITION

Your local composer is extractive: it can quote and stitch retrieved passages and *structurally cannot originate a claim*. That is a weaker system that reads more plainly — and it is also a system in which fabrication is unavailable rather than merely rare. Before you switch to a hosted model, put both in front of five real people and find out whether they prefer the fluent one. If they do not, you have just removed a cost line, a dependency and a cross-border transfer problem in one decision. **INFERENCE**

Explicitly not now

These are real gaps and they are not Horizon 1. Scope discipline is most of what makes an eight-week plan finish in eight weeks.

Contributor review queue	defer — proposals are recorded
Admin UI for incidents	defer — read-only list is enough
Embedding-model backfill script	defer — needed only when you change models
Rendered ERD	defer — the text diagram is accurate
Notification scheduling	never, by design — see §3, problem 4
Second region	Horizon 3, once you have customers in one
The asking artifact (§3)	Horizon 2 — it is a growth tool, not a launch blocker

7 The launch gate

One page. Print it. No real person's memories enter the system until every box is ticked and you have signed the bottom. If a box cannot be ticked, the answer is to fix it, not to add a caveat.

LEGAL AND ACCOUNTABILITY

- ☐ Counsel has answered the §5 brief, and the consent copy, teach-back wording, terms and succession screen carry their approval
- ☐ A policy exists for third parties named inside memories, and it is implemented, not merely written
- ☐ An accountable person is named by name in the runbook, on the support page, and in the customer agreement
- ☐ The name is cleared, or a rename has been completed
- ☐ Nothing on the public site claims traction, customers or capability that does not exist

SECURITY

- ☐ Production authentication works: no `AUTH_DRIVER=local`, MFA available, password reset working
- ☐ Every development secret has been replaced and lives in a secret manager
- ☐ Encryption at rest with a customer-managed key
- ☐ A real malware scanner is in the upload path
- ☐ An independent security review has been completed and its findings closed or explicitly accepted in writing

OPERATIONS

- ☐ Backups run, and a restore has been *performed* into a clean environment and timed
- ☐ A deletion has been performed end to end and verified against the database afterwards — not against the receipt
- ☐ Monitoring and alerting reach a human within minutes; that human has agreed to be reached
- ☐ Logs, error reports and support views have been inspected and contain no memory content
- ☐ All eight integrations have been executed, not merely deployed
- ☐ Billing works, including verified webhook signatures, and a refund has been tested

PRODUCT

- ☐ An accessibility review with disabled users has been completed and blocking findings fixed
- ☐ The interview capture path has been exercised by hand, on real hardware, by someone over seventy
- ☐ Export has been produced and opened without EverEcho present
- ☐ A written runbook exists for the death of a storyteller during the pilot (§18)
- ☐ Real unit costs are known, and the price covers them

SIGN IT

I confirm that every box above is ticked, that I have personally verified the ones marked *performed* rather than accepting a report, and that I am the person accountable if this goes wrong.

Signed _____ Date _____

This is not ceremony. The list contains four things that are routinely skipped — a rehearsed restore, a verified deletion, a log inspection, and an accessibility review with actual disabled people — and skipping any of them is invisible until the day it is catastrophic.

8 Horizon 2: the first ten families

HORIZON 2 Ten paying archives. Not a hundred. Not free ones.

Months 2-5

The purpose of this cohort is not revenue and not growth. It is to answer four questions that no amount of thinking will answer, and to produce the one asset that makes everything in Part IV easier.

The four questions

	QUESTION	HOW YOU WILL KNOW
Q1	Will anyone pay, at a price that works?	Ten families pay the \$5 provisional price without a discount. If you had to discount, the answer is no and you have learned it cheaply.
Q2	Will the storyteller actually do the work?	Payment → consent → first recording → first approved memory . Measure the drop at each step. This is the split-incentive problem from §3 meeting reality.
Q3	What does one archive really cost to serve?	Every hour you spend, logged. Every provider invoice, attributed. Fill in the §2 worksheet with real numbers.
Q4	Does the refusal actually sell, or merely survive?	Watch what people react to. If nobody mentions the citations or the abstention, your positioning is a private conviction rather than a market position — and §10 changes.

How to find ten families

Do not run advertising. At ten units, paid acquisition teaches you nothing and costs you focus. Go where the occasion already lives (§3, problem 3):

- 1

Your own circle first, but paying. Friends and family who pay full price are a real signal; ones you comp are a favour, and favours produce polite feedback that will mislead you for months.
- 2

One channel partner, unpaid pilot. A single estate planner, hospice, senior-living director or community organiser who will introduce you to three or four families. One partner, not five — you are testing whether the channel works, not building a channel programme.
- 3

A community with a reason. Diaspora and migration communities have an unusually strong version of this need: the generation that moved is ageing, and the story of *why* they moved is exactly what is lost first. Your own demonstration archive is built around precisely that. **INFERENCE**
- 4

Do the interviews yourself. All ten. This is the concierge phase from §2 and it is deliberately unscalable. You are writing the specification for what the product must eventually automate, and you cannot write it from a desk.

TWO RULES FOR THIS COHORT

Nobody gets it free. A free archive answers none of the four questions.

Nobody gets a discount to close. A discount converts Q1 from a measurement into a wish.

What would falsify the idea

Decide these thresholds *now*, before you are emotionally invested in ten specific families. Write them down and date them.

Fewer than 5 of 10 reach a first approved memory	the split-incentive problem is fatal as designed
Cost to serve exceeds price, and is not obviously automatable	the business does not work at this price
Nobody mentions citation or refusal, unprompted	reposition; the wedge is yours, not theirs
You cannot recruit 10 without paid acquisition	the channel thesis in §10 is wrong

None of these means stop. Each means *change something specific*, and knowing which is worth more than the ten customers.

PART III

Building the business

Price, channel, growth, measurement and team — the five things that turn ten families into a company.

9 Pricing and the business model

Section 2 established the constraint: a cheap price forecloses the outcome. This section turns that into a structure you can put on a page.

Price the occasion, not the software

Cost-plus pricing will produce a small number, because your marginal costs are genuinely low. Do not price that way. Ask instead what a family already spends at this moment in their lives — a professional photographer for a milestone celebration, an hour with an estate lawyer, a headstone, a funeral. Those are the anchors your buyer is actually holding, and they are all far above what a software subscription would suggest. INFERENCE

The structure I would use

COMPONENT	SHAPE	WHAT IT IS FOR
Capture	One-time, large	The guided interviews, the transcription, the structuring, the first biography draft, and the handholding. This is where the real work and the real cost sit, and where the value is most legible to the buyer.
Preservation	Annual, modest	Storage, backups, keeping it reachable, keeping it exportable. Recurring because the obligation is recurring.
Family access	Included, unlimited	Never charge per seat. Every additional family member increases the value, deepens retention (§3, problem 4) and costs almost nothing. Charging for them is the single most self-defeating pricing choice available to you.
Additional chapters	One-time, smaller	Years later, more sessions. Offered only when the family asks — never prompted, per §3.
Long-term preservation	Optional prepay	A stated term paid up front. Attractive to buyers, and dangerous to you — see the warning below.

As a starting heuristic, not a market observation: set **capture** in the band a family would pay a good professional for a day's work plus a deliverable, and set **annual preservation** at roughly a tenth to a fifth of that. That shape puts you in model C of §2 without any heroic assumptions. ASSUMPTION — validate in §8, cohort of ten

BEFORE YOU SELL ANY PREPAID PRESERVATION TERM

A one-time payment for long-term storage is revenue today and an obligation for decades. Three things must be true first: counsel has answered whether it creates trust, escrow or reserve obligations (§5, brief item 11); you have real storage costs from Horizon 1; and the term is **stated in years**, not described as “forever”. Never write the word forever on a pricing page. You cannot promise it, and the one thing this company cannot afford is a promise it cannot keep.

Decide the non-payment policy now, and publish it

A family will stop paying. Perhaps they cannot afford it; perhaps the storyteller has died and nobody feels able to make the decision. What happens to the archive is a question you must answer *before* anyone pays, in plain words, on the pricing page.

DECISION — WHAT LAPSE MEANS

The options are: delete after notice; freeze and retain read-only; retain fully at your cost; or export-and-close.

Recommendation: a long grace period, then **export-and-close** — you generate the full export, deliver it, confirm receipt, and then delete on a stated schedule. It keeps your storage liability bounded, it holds nothing hostage, and it is consistent with everything else the product promises. Your shutdown-and-portability commitments already point this way; make it the individual-account policy too.

Things you must never do, for money

Advertising against memories	prohibited — and would end the company
Selling or brokering data	prohibited
Training shared models on private archives	prohibited — refused by the policy compiler
Charging per question asked	perverse: it prices curiosity and rewards fluent guessing
Engagement-based pricing	directly contradicts §3, problem 4
Charging for export	the ability to leave must always be free
Charging per family member	taxes the thing that creates your retention

10 The channel question

Section 3 concluded that you cannot manufacture the occasion, so you must attach to people who already own it. This section says which people, in what order, and how to test one without committing to all of them.

What makes a channel good, for this product specifically

Owns the moment	is already present at a trigger event
Holds the trust	the family already takes their advice
Cannot touch simulation	your refusal is a requirement, not a quirk
Reaches the storyteller, not only the buyer	solves §3, problem 2
Has a budget or a fee relationship	can transact without a new purchase decision

The candidates, ranked

	CHANNEL	WHY IT FITS	THE PROBLEM WITH IT
1	Estate, will and private-client advisers	Present at exactly the moment a person is thinking about what they leave behind. High-trust, fee-based, used to handling sensitive family material. Clients skew to the right age and means.	Slow, relationship-driven sales. They will not risk their client relationship on an unproven vendor — which is precisely what §4's readiness document is for.
2	Senior living communities	Concentrated population, an activities budget, staff whose job is meaningful engagement, and a recurring institutional relationship rather than one family at a time.	Institutional procurement. Consent gets complicated when a facility introduces the service — the storyteller must still be the one who decides, and you must design so that it visibly is.
3	Hospice and palliative care	The most acute version of the need; legacy work is already part of good practice. Deeply values the refusal — no hospice can be near a simulation product.	The hardest possible operating conditions: little time, fragile participants, and a cohort where death during the engagement is not a risk but an expectation. Do not start here. Earn it.
4	Diaspora and community organisations	An unusually strong version of the need — the generation that migrated is ageing, and the reason they left is the first thing lost. Trusted community intermediaries; natural word of mouth.	Fragmented, often unfunded, and the buyer may be the community rather than the family. Test as a source of families, not as a revenue channel.
5	Archives, museums, universities	Oral-history practice already exists, with real methodology you can learn from. Budget for provenance and rights management. Values citation natively.	This is a different product with a different buyer, and it pulls you toward §4's infrastructure fork. Genuinely promising; a distraction before month twelve.
6	Direct consumer advertising	Fast to start.	Low intent, split incentive, no occasion, delayed verdict. Every structural problem in §3 is at its worst here. Not recommended before you have a proven channel.

DECISION — WHICH ONE TO TEST FIRST

Recommendation: estate and private-client advisers, one partner, during \$8. They combine trust, an owned occasion, a transacting relationship and a client base that can pay a model-C price. Senior living is the strong second and a better fit if your first ten families come through one. Hospice is where this product may matter most and it is the last one you should attempt, not the first — go there when your operations are boring and your death runbook has been used.

How to test a channel without building a channel programme

- 1 **One partner. One.** Five partners produce five weak relationships and no signal.
- 2 **Ask for introductions, not a contract.** Three or four families is a complete test. Revenue share and paperwork can wait until you know it works.
- 3 **Give them the readiness document unprompted.** Their real question is what happens to their reputation if this goes wrong. Answering it before they ask is the fastest trust you will ever buy.
- 4 **Watch who actually does the asking.** If the adviser will not raise it with a client, the channel is dead however enthusiastic they were in the meeting. Enthusiasm is not distribution.
- 5 **Instrument it:** introductions made, families who took a call, families who paid, families who reached a first approved memory. Four numbers. If introductions are high and calls are low, your asking artifact is weak. If calls are high and payment is low, your price or your proof is wrong.

THE CONSENT TRAP IN EVERY INSTITUTIONAL CHANNEL

When a facility, an adviser or a hospice introduces the service, there is a structural risk that the storyteller feels the decision has already been made for them by someone with authority over their care or their money. Your product refuses to proceed without them — but refusing is not enough if the person feels obliged.

Design against it explicitly: the storyteller's consent conversation happens **without the introducing party present**, declining is unremarkable and costs the family nothing, and the partner is never told why an archive did not proceed. Write this into the partner agreement. It will lose you a small amount of revenue and it is not negotiable — a consent obtained under institutional pressure is the exact failure this entire product exists to prevent. **INFERENCE**

11 Growth without breaking your own rules

Most growth playbooks are unavailable to you, and not by accident — you removed them on purpose. This section says exactly what is closed, what remains, and why what remains is unusually strong.

What is closed to you

STANDARD TACTIC	WHY YOU CANNOT USE IT
Content-based targeting and retargeting	Memory content may never reach analytics. The constraint is enforced in the code that builds each event, not left to discipline. VERIFIED
Engagement email, digests, streaks, reminders	There is no notification scheduler, deliberately. Reminders about a parent's mortality become guilt with almost no effort. VERIFIED
Rich behavioural analytics from third-party SDKs	Most consumer analytics tooling assumes it may see page content. Yours may not. Expect to build a small amount of first-party measurement instead.
Testimonials quoting real memories	Possible, but only under a separate, explicit, revocable marketing consent that is never a condition of service and never bundled into the main flow. Treat every such quote as borrowed, not owned.
Referral mechanics with social pressure	"Invite your siblings before it's too late" is precisely the guilt loop the product prohibits.
Urgency and scarcity marketing	The honest version of urgency here is a person's death. Do not go near it.

What remains — and it is better than what you gave up

1. GIVE AWAY THE QUESTIONS

The interview question set is your most valuable and least protectable asset, and §3 established that *interview quality is the actual product*. Publish it: a free, beautiful, genuinely useful guide to interviewing your own parents, with no product requirement at all. Most people who download it will do nothing, some will try and discover how hard it is to do well, and a few will come back and pay you to do it properly. It costs nothing, it is honest, it demonstrates expertise better than any claim, and it is the single best top-of-funnel asset available to this business. INFERENCE

2. PUBLISH THE READINESS DOCUMENT

As argued in §4. Radical transparency about your own gaps is both a trust asset and a story journalists will actually run, because almost nobody does it.

3. BE THE CONTRASTING QUOTE

Stories about AI resurrection products appear regularly, and every one needs someone credible to say what the responsible version looks like. That person can be you, and it costs you nothing but availability. Write the position clearly once, keep it current, and be easy to reach.

4. THE ASKING ARTIFACT

From §3, problem 2 — the letter or page a child gives a parent. It is a product feature and a growth mechanism at once, because it travels between exactly the two people who must both agree. It does not exist yet. Build it in Horizon 2.

5. THE PHYSICAL DELIVERABLE

The printed biography draft is a marketing object that sits on a table and gets picked up by visitors. In a category with a delayed verdict (§3, problem 5), a tangible artefact is how you get word of mouth a decade before the archive is truly needed.

6. INFORMATIONAL SEARCH

People search for how to record a parent's stories, what to ask a grandparent, how to preserve old photographs. Those searches are the closest thing this category has to declared intent, and answering them well is a durable asset that does not require you to say anything untrue.

THE PATTERN

Every channel that remains open to you works by **being genuinely useful before anyone pays**, rather than by manufacturing pressure. That is slower. It is also the only kind of growth that is consistent with the product, and consistency here is not a nicety — the moment your marketing behaves differently from your product, the trust that is your entire differentiator is gone, and it does not come back.

12 The metrics that matter

Fewer than you think, and several of them are unusual. Two of the standard ones will actively mislead you if you track them.

The five that decide whether this works

METRIC	DEFINITION	WHY
Time to first approved memory	Payment → the storyteller approving their first memory	Your true activation event. Everything before it is a promise; this is the moment the product has done something. Directly measures \$3, problem 2.
Archive completeness	Decades, relationships and themes covered versus a target shape	The only early proxy for a verdict that otherwise arrives years late (\$3, problem 5). Turns an unmeasurable outcome into a visible gap.
Members per archive	People with active access	Your real retention driver. Each additional member makes cancelling less thinkable.
Gross margin, per cohort	Revenue minus cost to serve, by month of joining	The alarm for the \$2 margin trap. If cohort margin is not improving as you automate, concierge has quietly become the company.
Twelve-month retention	Archives still paying after a year	The only retention number that means anything for a custody product. Measure it annually; do not infer it from monthly activity.

Two that are specific to what you built

METRIC	WHAT IT TELLS YOU
Abstention rate questions answered with the refusal sentence	A health metric with a <i>band</i> , not a target. Too low and something is answering things it should not — check verification. Too high and either the archive is too thin (a completeness problem, tell the family) or retrieval has broken (an engineering problem). Alert on movement in either direction; a sudden drop is the most dangerous signal this system can produce.
Consent narrowing and revocation rate	People tightening their permissions is a trust signal in reverse. A rise means something in the product, the marketing or a partner made someone uncomfortable. Read the audit log, do not just count.

Do not track these

Daily or monthly active users	a finished archive is unopened by design; this number will panic you over nothing
Session length, time in app	optimising it means manufacturing engagement, which is prohibited
Questions asked per week	same trap, and it prices curiosity
Net promoter score in year one	the verdict arrives years late; you would be measuring politeness

All of the above must be computed without memory content ever reaching an analytics store — which is achievable for every metric listed, and is the reason none of them requires knowing what any archive contains.

13 The team, in hiring order

Five roles, each with the trigger that says it is time. Hiring before the trigger burns money you do not have; hiring after it means you have already been the bottleneck for a month.

	ROLE	HIRE WHEN	WHY THIS ORDER
1	Interviewer / storyteller success	You are conducting more than about six interviews a month, or interviews are being scheduled around your availability	Interview quality <i>is</i> the product (§3, problem 5), and it is the first thing that breaks when you get busy. Hire for warmth and curiosity, not for technology — oral history, journalism, social work, chaplaincy and teaching all produce good candidates.
2	Engineer	You are choosing between shipping and selling in the same week, more than once	Everything is TypeScript with no build step and 279 passing tests, so a competent engineer is productive quickly. Have them start by taking the deployment and on-call, which is the work that most fragments a founder's attention.
3	Privacy and legal operations fractional first	A second jurisdiction, a first institutional contract, or the first data-subject request from someone who is not a customer	The third-party-in-memories question (§5, brief item 4) will generate real operational work. Fractional is right until it isn't; the trigger for full-time is a second regulator.
4	Partnerships	One channel has produced families twice, repeatably, without you personally in the room	Hiring this before the channel is proven means paying someone to discover that your thesis was wrong — which you can discover yourself for free in §8 and §10.
5	Support lead	Support minutes per archive × live archives exceeds what one person can absorb alongside another job	See the warning below. This is not a normal support hire and staffing it like one will hurt someone.

SUPPORT HERE IS NOT NORMAL SUPPORT

Your support inbox will contain a message from someone whose parent died last week asking why a recording will not play. It will contain families in conflict about who may see what. It will contain a person who wants to delete everything, at midnight, and means it.

Staff this deliberately: written escalation paths, a hard rule that nobody handles these alone, access to actual supervision, and a workload that assumes emotional labour rather than ticket throughput. And note the constraint you built — the support view shows operational metadata only, never memory content — which is right, and which means your support people will sometimes be helping with something they cannot see. Train for that explicitly.

VERIFIED — scope is metadata-only in code

Who not to hire, and when not to

A growth marketer, early	most of the standard playbook is closed to you (\$11); they will be frustrated and you will waste the hire
A salesperson before the channel is proven	see role 4's trigger
An AI/ML specialist	the retrieval and verification are done and deliberately conservative; there is no model problem to solve yet
A designer, full-time, early	the interface is built and passes accessibility; use contract design for the asking artifact and the printed deliverable

The one thing you should not delegate

Conduct interviews yourself for longer than is comfortable — well past the first ten. It is the only place where you learn what the product must become, and it is the first thing every founder in your position hands off, because it does not feel like work on the company. It is the work on the company.

PART IV

Money

Whether to raise it, how to raise it if you do, and the staged path the arithmetic in §2 actually implies.

14 Bootstrap or raise

The generic answer is “raise, because you want a large outcome.” For this business the generic answer is wrong about the timing and right about the destination.

The case for not raising yet

- **Nothing is racing you.** There is no network effect, no land grab, no winner-take-all dynamic. Nobody wins this market by being six months earlier; they win it by being trusted, and trust does not respond to capital.
- **The concierge phase earns money from the first customer.** Model C pricing on ten families is real revenue during the period you would otherwise be fundraising.
- **Capital creates pressure toward exactly the features you have prohibited.** A board watching flat engagement will, sincerely and reasonably, ask why you will not add the voice. Every prohibition in this product is a growth constraint, which is the whole point, and money makes constraints feel like problems.
- **You have no answer yet to the questions money would make urgent.** Raising before \$8 means spending someone else's money to discover your price and your channel — which you can discover for far less.

The case for raising

- **You asked for a billion-dollar outcome.** Reaching \$100M of recurring revenue without external capital is rare enough that planning for it would be planning on an exception. **INFERENCE**
- **The launch gate costs real money.** An independent security review, counsel in multiple jurisdictions, encryption infrastructure, a real scanner and hosting are not small sums, and none of them is optional.
- **Channel sales cycles are long.** Estate advisers and senior-living operators move over quarters. That requires runway, not hustle.
- **Preservation is a balance-sheet promise.** Committing to hold something for decades is more credible from a company with capital than from one person with a card.

DECISION — THE SEQUENCE I RECOMMEND

Bootstrap through \$8. Then raise a small round on the strength of ten paying families.

Ten families who paid full price, with a measured cost to serve, a real activation rate and one channel that produced introductions, is a stronger fundraising asset than any deck you could write instead — and it costs you three months rather than three months of meetings. It also inverts the power in the conversation, which matters enormously for the next point.

And the part almost nobody plans: choose investors by whether they will accept the \$17 governance terms in writing. An investor who treats the prohibitions as a phase is not a cheaper investor — they are a future fight over the thing your company exists to be. Raise less, from people who understand what they are funding.

15 If you raise

The narrative

Do not lead with the family archive. Lead with the thesis, because the thesis is what makes the archive interesting:

“The industry is racing to simulate dead people. That is going to fail publicly and badly, and when it does, every serious institution — every hospice, university, bank and family — will need the version that refuses. We built that version first, and the hard part is not the product. It is the consent and provenance machinery underneath it, which took eight months and which nobody copies in a quarter.”

The order to present in

- 1 The problem, told through the failure mode: a grieving family believing a fabricated answer.
- 2 The refusal, as a position rather than a policy — and the demo pair from §3, live.
- 3 What is actually built: 279 tests, forced isolation, 100% claim-to-citation, zero permission leaks, all measured.
- 4 The ten families: price paid, activation rate, cost to serve, channel origin.
- 5 Why the machinery is the moat, and the optionality in §4.
- 6 The channel thesis, with the one partner that worked.
- 7 The arithmetic from §2, honestly — including why you are not building a cheap consumer subscription.
- 8 The readiness document, handed over unprompted.
- 9 What the money buys, tied to the §16 stage you are trying to reach.

What you will be asked, and what is actually true

THE QUESTION	THE HONEST ANSWER
<i>"Why not add voice cloning? Users will want it."</i>	The one that matters. Answer: because the archive is only worth filling if the storyteller believes it will never be used that way, and a company that would add it later is one they must reason about today. Then point out that it is refused by a policy compiler and a test, not by a promise — which is why institutions can buy it. Prepare this answer word for word. You will give it in every meeting.
<i>"Isn't the market small?"</i>	Show \$2. The answer is not that the market is large; it is that revenue per archive can be large, and here is the price ten families actually paid.
<i>"What's your CAC?"</i>	UNKNOWN , and say so. Then say precisely how you will find out and by when. A founder who says "I don't know yet, here's the experiment" is more credible than one with a confident invented number — and this is a company whose entire pitch is not inventing numbers.
<i>"Why won't they churn once the archive is finished?"</i>	Custody, not engagement (\$3, problem 4). Members per archive is the retention driver. Be honest that twelve-month retention is not yet measured.
<i>"Why can't a large platform do this tomorrow?"</i>	They can build the features. What they will not do is adopt the refusal, because it is directly opposed to their engagement and data incentives — and without the refusal, the product is the thing you are not.
<i>"What happens when someone dies?"</i>	Answer operationally, not philosophically: the succession directive, the runbook, and the honest note that no automatic transition can ever be triggered by inactivity.

Where you will be attacked, fairly

Services margin inside model C	answer with the cohort margin trend from \$12
Perpetual storage liability	answer with the \$9 policy and the stated term
Category contamination with griefbots	answer by making it your acquisition channel
No traction	answer with ten paying families and the readiness document
Single founder, if you are one	answer with the hiring triggers in \$13

16 The staged path to scale

Five stages. Each has one thing that must become true before the next is attempted, and a branch point where the honest answer might be to change direction rather than push harder.

STAGE	ARCHIVES	ROUGHLY	WHAT MUST BECOME TRUE	BRANCH IF IT DOESN'T
0	10	Month 5	People pay full price and storytellers reach a first approved memory	Reprice, or fix activation. Do not proceed on hope.
1	100	Year 1	One channel produces families repeatably without you in the room. Capture is partly productised. Cohort margin is rising.	Try the second channel in \$10. If two fail, the channel thesis is wrong and consumer-direct must be tested properly.
2	1,000	Year 2-3	Gross margin approaching software rather than services. Interviewers are hired and trained, not you. Twelve-month retention measured and acceptable.	The real branch point. If margin is stuck, this is a services business — a good one, but not the \$2 outcome. Decide deliberately whether that is acceptable.
3	10,000	Year 4-5	Multiple channels. Institutional accounts (model D) contributing. Operations boring enough to survive a bad week.	If consumer stalls but institutions pull, follow the pull — that is the \$4 infrastructure fork opening legitimately.
4	50,000	Year 6-7	Model C revenue per archive sustained at scale ⇒ approximately \$100M ARR ⇒ the \$2 arithmetic.	—

What that growth rate actually means

From	10 archives
To	50,000 archives
Over	~6 years
Sustained annual growth required	~4× per year

Sustaining roughly four-fold growth for six consecutive years is the shape of companies that reach this outcome. It is also where most attempts stop — typically between stages 2 and 3, when the founder-led magic stops working and the machine that replaces it has not been built. INFERENCE

THE STAGE-2 TO STAGE-3 TRANSITION IS THE WHOLE GAME

Everything before stage 2 you can do through effort and taste. Everything after it requires that the quality of an interview does not depend on you being in the room. That is a training, tooling and standards problem, and it is the one to start solving at stage 1 — a year before you need it — because founders who wait until they feel the pain take eighteen months to recover from it.

Two honest observations about this table

First: stages 0 and 1 are things I would bet on. Stage 2 is genuinely uncertain and depends on a margin question nobody can answer from here. Stages 3 and 4 are arithmetic, not forecasts — they describe what would have to happen, not what will.

Second: stopping at stage 2 or 3 is not failure. A company with a thousand or ten thousand families, sound margins and an intact promise is a good outcome by any measure that is not this document's title. Keep that in view, because the arithmetic in §2 has a way of making a real business feel like a disappointment, and that feeling has ended more good companies than any competitor.

PART V

Governance and risk

How to make the refusal survive you, what will actually go wrong, and the conditions under which I would tell you to stop.

17 Binding the refusal so it survives you

Today the prohibitions hold because you wrote them and you care. That is the weakest form of guarantee there is, and the whole product's value rests on it.

Why this is urgent rather than philosophical

The pressure to add the voice will not arrive as a villain. It will arrive as a good person with a good argument at a bad moment: a board member after two flat quarters, an acquirer whose offer changes your family's life, a large customer who will sign if you add just one feature, or a grieving user who begs you for it. Every one of those is a sincere request, and the reason to decide now is that you will not be at your most clear-headed in any of those rooms.

You already did the technical half: a policy compiler that refuses, a function that discards first-person output, database constraints, and tests that fail if any of it is removed. VERIFIED But code is changed by whoever controls the company, and right now that protection is exactly as strong as your continued ownership.

The instruments, from cheapest to strongest

	INSTRUMENT	WHAT IT DOES	COST
1	Publish the prohibitions as terms	Makes them a promise every customer can hold you to, not a marketing claim. Enforceable by the people they protect.	A page and counsel's time. Do this before the first customer.
2	A purpose clause in the constitutional documents	Names the prohibited activities in the company's own governing document, so removing them is a formal act with a paper trail rather than a product decision.	Incorporation-time work. Far harder to add later.
3	Reserved matters	Changing the prohibitions requires a supermajority or a specific consent, so no ordinary board majority can do it quietly.	Must be negotiated <i>before</i> you take money, which is why §14 says choose investors on this.
4	An outside voice with a real veto	One or two independent people — an ethicist, a palliative-care clinician, an archivist — with a defined and narrow veto over the prohibited list. Not an advisory board; advisory boards advise.	Modest fees, and the discipline of being argued with.
5	Change-of-control protections	On acquisition, the prohibitions survive, and every family gets notice plus a guaranteed window to export and delete. It makes the archives less useful to a buyer who wants them for the wrong reason — which is the point.	Real. It may reduce your exit price, and that is the trade you are choosing.
6	Publish the enforcing tests	Anyone can verify the refusal is still enforced in the shipped product. Turns a claim into something falsifiable by strangers.	Nearly free. Uniquely credible.

DECISION — HOW FAR TO GO

Recommendation: do 1, 2 and 6 now — before the first customer and before incorporation is final, because two of them are much harder to retrofit. **Negotiate 3 and 5 into the first round** in §14. **Add 4 at stage 1**, when there are real families whose interests deserve representation that is not you.

Instrument 5 is the one that will feel expensive, so be clear-eyed: you are deliberately lowering the value of an exit to a buyer whose plan is to remove the refusal. That is not a sacrifice made against your interest — it is the thing that makes the promise real, and the promise is the company.

18 The risk register

Ranked by expected damage, not by how alarming they sound. The first one is not a risk — it is a certainty you are not yet prepared for.

#	RISK	LIKELIHOOD	MITIGATION	EARLY WARNING
1	A storyteller dies mid-engagement	certain	A written runbook, before the first family. See below.	None. It simply happens.
2	A family conflict over access	high	The dispute-hold mechanism exists in the schema; write the human policy for who decides and on what evidence.	Access requests from people the storyteller did not invite.
3	A third party objects to appearing in a memory	medium-high	Counsel brief item 4; likely needs a redaction path and an objection route in product.	The first such email. Do not improvise a reply.
4	Cost to serve exceeds price	medium-high	Fill the \$2 worksheet in Horizon 1; watch cohort margin monthly (\$12).	Cohort margin flat across three cohorts.
5	Founder is the single point of failure	medium-high	Hiring triggers in \$13; document operations as you go; the runbook must be usable by someone else.	You have not taken a full week off, and cannot.
6	A fabrication reaches a family and is believed	low-medium	Verification and third-person assertion already run on every answer; the abstention band in \$12 is the alarm.	Abstention rate falls without an obvious cause. Treat as an incident.
7	A breach	low-medium	The launch gate; encryption with a customer-managed key; independent review; forced isolation already in place.	Anything anomalous in the audit trail. Read it weekly (\$20).
8	A channel partner pressures a storyteller	medium	The partner-agreement rules in \$10 — consent conversation without the partner present, declining is costless, no feedback on why.	A rise in consent narrowing or revocation from one partner's families (\$12).
9	Acquisition or investor pressure to remove the refusal	medium	Every instrument in \$17. This is what they are for.	The first time you hear yourself say “maybe just for enterprise”.
10	Provider dependency	medium	Every provider sits behind an adapter with a working local implementation — this risk is already largely engineered away. Keep it that way.	A pricing change email from a speech-to-text vendor.
11	Reputational contamination with griefbots	medium	\$4 and \$11 — own the distinction loudly and early.	Being described as one, in writing, by someone who read your site.
12	Regulatory action	low, if \$5 is done	The counsel brief, honestly answered and implemented.	A data-subject request you do not know how to answer.

RISK 1 IN FULL: WRITE THIS RUNBOOK BEFORE THE FIRST FAMILY

Your product is for older people, and you will be working with a cohort of them for months. **Someone in your first fifty families will die during the engagement.** This is not a risk to be mitigated; it is a scheduled event whose date is unknown.

What must be decided in advance, in writing, while it is still abstract:

- How you find out, and who tells you.
- What happens to a half-finished archive — recordings not yet transcribed, memories not yet approved. **Nobody but the storyteller can approve them, and the storyteller is gone.** Decide now what unapproved material means after death. This is the hardest question in the product and it has no default answer.
- Who may act: the succession directive, if one exists, and what happens if it does not.
- What you send the family, and when. Not a system email. A person.
- Billing: suspended immediately, no renewal notice, no dunning. Check that your payment provider cannot send an automated reminder — this is the most likely way you cause real pain, and it is entirely preventable.
- Who on your team is told, and how they are supported.

Rehearse it once, out loud, before you need it. It is a grim hour and it is the single highest-value hour of preparation available to this company. **INFERENCE**

19 When I would tell you to stop

A chief of staff who cannot say this is not doing the job. These are the conditions under which continuing would be the wrong call, written now while neither of us is invested in the answer.

Stop, or change something fundamental

Fewer than half of paying families reach a first approved memory, after two attempts to fix it	the split incentive is fatal as designed
Cost to serve exceeds price and no automation path is visible by 100 archives	the arithmetic does not close
Two channels tested properly, neither produced families repeatably	there is no distribution, and nothing else matters
Counsel's answer on third parties in memories requires a change that breaks the product	rethink the shape, not the effort
You cannot raise and cannot fund the launch gate	do not launch under-secured — stop instead

Reasons that are not reasons to stop

It is growing more slowly than you hoped	expected; the verdict is delayed by design
A competitor with voice cloning raises a large round	that is your positioning arriving, not your market leaving
Engagement metrics look bad	you should not be measuring them (\$12)
Someone tells you the market is too small	answer with \$2, then carry on
It is emotionally heavy work	true, and a reason to staff and supervise it properly — not to stop

AND THE ONE THAT OUTRANKS ALL OF THEM

If continuing would require removing the refusal — the voice, the face, the persona, the simulation of someone who died — then the honest answer is that the company you would be continuing is not this one. Stop, or sell it to someone bound by \$17, and be at peace with either. A version of EverEcho that simulates people is not a compromised EverEcho; it is the thing EverEcho was built to be an alternative to.

PART VI

Your operating system

The cadence that keeps this on track, the first thirty days in detail, and every decision currently waiting on you.

20 The cadence

Founders do not fail from lack of effort; they fail from losing the thread. A fixed cadence is how you notice a problem in week three instead of month five.

Every Monday — 45 minutes, alone

- 1 **Read the audit trail.** Not a summary — the actual log, including refusals. Your own readiness document names this as a condition for piloting, and it is also how you find risk 7 before someone else does. Fifteen minutes.
- 2 **The five metrics from §12.** Written down, in the same place, every week, so the trend is visible rather than remembered.
- 3 **The abstention band.** Movement in either direction is an incident until proven otherwise.
- 4 **Open decisions (§22).** Anything sitting for more than two weeks is either not important or being avoided. Decide which, out loud.
- 5 **One sentence:** what is the single most important thing this week? Write it where you will see it on Thursday.

Every month — 2 hours

- **Cohort margin.** The §2 margin trap alarm. If it is not improving, say so plainly in writing rather than assuming next month.
- **Unit costs against reality.** Provider invoices attributed to archives. Hours logged and costed, including yours.
- **The falsification thresholds from §8.** Reread them. They were written by a more objective version of you.
- **One customer conversation you did not need to have.** Not a support ticket — a conversation.
- **Update the decision log.** The company deserves the same discipline the codebase got.

Every quarter — half a day

- **Are you at the stage you thought?** Against §16, honestly.
- **Risk register review (§18).** Likelihoods change. So do the early-warning signs.
- **The refusal audit.** Has anything shipped that weakens it? Do the enforcing tests still exist and still run? Has anyone asked you to remove it, and what did you say?
- **Governance progress (§17).** Which instruments are in place, which are still intentions.
- **Your own state.** Risk 5 is you. It is a real line item and it does not appear on any dashboard.

KEEP A DECISION LOG FOR THE COMPANY

The repository has one — fifteen decisions, each with its reasoning, which is why the architecture is still coherent. Do the same for the business: the decision, the date, the reasoning, what would change your mind. In eighteen months you will not remember why you chose a price, a channel or a jurisdiction, and the reasoning is worth more than the choice.

21 The first thirty days

DAY 1 - DAY 30 Concrete. In order. Start the external clocks first.

Starting Monday

DAYS 1-2 — THINGS THAT COST HOURS AND BUY WEEKS

- ☐ Fix the pricing-page tense so the site claims no families you do not have
- ☐ Name yourself as the accountable person in `INCIDENT_RUNBOOK.md`, commit it
- ☐ Begin trademark clearance on the name
- ☐ Send the §5 brief to two or three data-protection lawyers; ask each the deceased-persons question
- ☐ Email three candidate security reviewers for availability and cost in week 6
- ☐ Ask two disability organisations about a paid accessibility review in week 7

DAYS 3-7 — DECIDE WHAT IS YOURS TO DECIDE

- ☐ Work through §5 decisions 2, 5, 6 and 7; write each into the company decision log with its reasoning
- ☐ Draft the prohibitions as customer-facing terms (§17, instrument 1)
- ☐ Choose the hosting provider and region
- ☐ List every development secret that must be replaced

DAYS 8-14 — THE BIGGEST ENGINEERING PIECE

- ☐ Production authentication: OIDC or passkeys, MFA enrolment, **and password reset**
- ☐ Real secrets in a secret manager; no `dev-only-...` string survives
- ☐ Deploy to a real environment for the first time, with synthetic data only

DAYS 15-21 — MAKE THE UNPROVEN THINGS PROVEN

- ☐ Run all eight integrations, in the §6 order, checking the stated first thing for each
- ☐ **Record your real unit costs as you go** — this is the week the §2 worksheet gets filled in
- ☐ Wire Stripe webhook signature verification; test a payment and a refund end to end
- ☐ Compare the local extractive composer against the hosted one, and decide whether you need the hosted one at all

DAYS 22-30 — THE THINGS THAT ARE SKIPPED

- ☐ Encryption at rest with a customer-managed key
- ☐ A real malware scanner in the upload path
- ☐ Backups configured, and a restore *performed* into a clean environment and timed
- ☐ A deletion performed end to end and verified against the database, not the receipt
- ☐ Monitoring and alerting that reach your phone
- ☐ Inspect logs, error reports and the support view for memory content; fix anything found
- ☐ **Write the death runbook (§18) and read it aloud once**
- ☐ Set the provisional price and update the pricing page

AT THE END OF DAY 30 YOU SHOULD HAVE

A deployed system with real authentication, proven integrations, known unit costs, a price, working billing, and every external clock running. What you will *not* have is a single real memory in the database — and that is correct. Weeks 5–8 close the launch gate; the first family comes after it, not before.

22 Open decisions, waiting on you

Everything in this document that requires a human judgement, consolidated. Nothing here can be delegated, deferred indefinitely, or resolved by more engineering.

#	DECISION	BY WHEN	WHERE	MY RECOMMENDATION
1	Keep the name or rename	Week 3	\$5	Clear it now; rename immediately if not clearly clearable
2	Jurisdiction and data region	Week 2	\$5	Where your first ten families are, not your hundred-thousandth
3	Which counsel, and engage them	Week 1	\$5	Data-protection specialist; test them on deceased-persons data
4	Named accountable person	Day 1	\$5	You, in writing, today
5	Audio-first, or audio and video	Week 2	\$5	Audio default; video as a priced upgrade with a stated term
6	The provisional price	Week 4	\$5, \$9	Capture fee large, preservation annual, family access free
7	What lapse in payment means	Before first sale	\$9	Long grace, then export-and-close on a stated schedule
8	Prepaid preservation: offer it or not	Before first sale	\$9	Only after counsel answers brief item 11, and never as “forever”
9	Which channel to test first	Week 6	\$10	Estate and private-client advisers; one partner only
10	The falsification thresholds	Before family 1	\$8	Write them down and date them while you are still objective
11	Bootstrap or raise	Month 5	\$14	Bootstrap through the first ten; then raise small, from aligned investors
12	Which governance instruments, and when	Weeks 2–4	\$17	Instruments 1, 2 and 6 now; 3 and 5 into the first round; 4 at stage 1
13	Whether to publish the readiness document	Month 1	\$4	Yes. It is the cheapest credibility available to you
14	Hosted composition, or keep the extractive one	Week 3	\$6	Test both on real people before you assume you need the fluent one
15	What unapproved material means after a death	Before family 1	\$18	The hardest question here, and it has no default. Decide it while it is abstract

THREE OF THESE ARE QUIETLY URGENT

#4 takes ten minutes and is currently blocking your own launch gate. #3 runs on someone else's calendar and gates everything legal. #15 is the one you will be tempted to leave until it happens — and it is the one you will handle worst if you do.

A closing note

You asked me to guide you to a unicorn. I have given you the arithmetic that outcome requires, the sequence that makes it possible, and the places where I think it most likely breaks. Here is what I actually believe.

The hardest thing about this company is not the technology, and you have already proved that by finishing the part everyone else fakes. It is that you have chosen a business whose central promise is a refusal — and refusals do not demo, do not go viral, and do not respond to the ordinary levers. Every structural problem in §3 traces back to that single choice.

It is still the right choice, and not for sentimental reasons. It is the only version of this product that institutions can adopt, that reluctant storytellers will fill honestly, and that survives the moment when the first simulation company is publicly disgraced. You are not building a safer version of a category. You are building the version that is left standing.

What I would hold you to, if I were actually sitting beside you:

- **Do not choose a cheap price.** It is the one decision that forecloses everything you asked me about, and it is usually made in an afternoon by someone who feels awkward asking for money.
- **Do not put a real memory in that database before the gate in §7 closes.** Not one. Not your own grandmother's.
- **Bind the refusal while it is easy** — before investors, before an acquirer, before a bad quarter makes it feel negotiable.
- **Keep doing the interviews yourself** long past the point it feels like a good use of your time. It is where the product actually comes from.
- **Publish what is not finished.** The readiness document, the gaps, the things that never ran. It is your strangest asset and your most durable one.

And one honest thing about the word in your question. Nobody can hand you a unicorn, and this document has not tried to. What it has tried to do is make sure that if this company does not become one, it will be for reasons outside your control — not because you priced it cheaply in month two, launched before it was safe, or traded away the promise in a difficult week.

A thousand families with an intact promise is a real company and a good life's work. Fifty thousand is the arithmetic in §2. Both begin the same way: fix a sentence on your pricing page, name yourself accountable, send the brief to counsel, and start the clock.

Every claim in this document is labelled with its evidence class. Nothing here is a market figure I could not verify, a statistic I could not source, or a projection presented as a fact. It was written to the same standard as the product it describes, which seemed like the only defensible way to write it.